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Culture (OWC): [San \(FX10\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: 1963-1966

Coverage Date: 1963-1965

Place Coverage: Dobe Area, Botswana

Section Title(S)

GROUP STRUCTURE • KINSHIP AND THE NAME RELATION

The causes of the high turnover may be found in demographic factors, particularly in the vagaries of family size and sex ratios of very small populations. Given the small family size and the likelihood of disparities of sex ratios, the probability is extremely small that a family would be able to maintain its numbers at an ecologically viable level if it had to depend solely on natural replacement. For example, if the rule of residence were strictly patrilocal, the waterhole group with all daughters would be quickly put out of business, while the waterhole group with a preponderance of male offspring would have far more hunters on hand than the limited game could support.

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A far more adaptive way of maintaining group size and of distributing population with reference to resources is to allow many different avenues of group affiliation. The flexible group structure of the Dobe area is the result. The !Kung do not resort to elaborate fictions to bring living arrangements on the ground into line with an ideal model. They simply leave group and geographic boundaries open and allow the most effective subsistence units to emerge anew in each generation.

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KINSHIP AND THE NAME RELATION⁹

If the !Kung had to rely on genealogical reckoning alone, their kin universe would be severely circumscribed. Their genealogical knowledge is of shallow depth; only one or two generations beyond the oldest ascendants are known, and they rapidly lose track of cousins beyond the second degree. This primary kinship system, however, is only the start for an elaborate development of

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fictive kinship based on the common possession of personal names. There is a limited repertoire of personal names among the !Kung: only thirty-five men's names and thirty-four women's names were in use in the Dobe area in 1964. All names are sex-specific and there are no surnames. Personal names are transmitted from grandparent to grandchild according to strict rules of precedence. There are no "new" names, and the current repertoire appears to have been handed down over many generations. A first-born male is named after his father's father, and a first-born female after her father's mother. The second-born of each sex are named for their maternal grandparents. If further children are born, they are named after siblings of their parents or more distant relatives. A parent may never name a child after himself.

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This is only a bare introduction to the many complexities of !Kung naming rules. Readers desiring to go further into the matter are urged to consult Lorna Marshall's classic paper, "The Kin Terminology System of the !Kung Bushmen" (1957).

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Their naming system enables the !Kung to extend primary kinship ties far beyond the boundaries of personal genealogical kindreds. In fact, the [357](#) thousands of !Kung language speakers are connected by name relations into a network of fictive kinship that extends all the way from Angola in the north to Ghanzi five hundred miles to the south in central Botswana. The basic principle is that bearers of the same name have a special affectionate relation with one another, and they use the kin terms "old name—young name" regardless of the actual biological connection. It obtains even in cases where there is no traceable connection at all. The !Kung believe that all persons holding a given name are descended from the original bearer of that name. In the Dobe area, 22 of the 223 men are named *ǀoma*, and whenever *ǀomas* meet they enjoy the familiarity of the joking relation. The bonds are particularly strong among men who actually share a common ancestral namesake. For instance, nine of the twelve men named */i!ay* in the Dobe area are descended from a single prolific */i!ay*. Of him it can truly be said that his name is legion.

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9. A detailed discussion of Bushman kinship and the name relation will be published elsewhere.

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